denunciation of Indian freedom and called Nehru a hireling of Anglo-American imperialism'.[41] Attempting to prevent Chinese criticism from undermining his (and India's) position as the self-declared leader of Asian nationalism, Nehru became determined to demonstrably distance India from the United States 'to disprove Mao's view, congruent with that of the Soviets, that India was still subordinate to Great Britain and the United States'.[42]

Indian diplomacy was thus placed in the curious position of subverting US-India relations, ignoring its own strategic considerations and becoming China's foremost supporter on the world stage for the singular purpose of negating communist propaganda. In doing so, not only did India barter away the legal rights it had inherited in Tibet[43] and champion China's position at the United Nations, it also sought to actively obstruct American efforts to support the Tibetan cause materially and diplomatically (more on that to follow) – all in an attempt to demonstrate its friendship for the People's Republic and its distance from the United States. In the process, it also sought to burnish Nehru's anti-colonial credentials and showcase Asianism in action.

Matters came to a head during the Korean war, when Nehru's attempt at mediation – against the advice of Patel and Secretary-General Girija Shankar Bajpai of the Ministry of External Affairs – was rebuffed by the United States.[44] Conversely, Nehru continued to advocate the Chinese position, criticizing the American move to cross the 38th parallel and pushing the Truman administration to accept Chinese demands for a seat in the UN Security Council and the vacation of Formosa. The policy of 'non-alignment on its merits' was given a quiet burial, and stripped of its moral qualities, redefined as neutrality, as the Indian government avoided criticism of China even after it entered the war on the North Korean side.

During the Korean conflict Indian policy effectively shifted 'to a posture of deference to international communism'[45] – heightening American distrust and leading US policymakers to conclude that Nehru was either a supporter of communist expansion or dangerously naïve in his assessment.